

The National Fire Ant Eradication Program's National Management Group (NMG) held its third meeting over two sessions in May and June.

NMG members received a program update which outlined the strategy to deliver the 2024-25 work plan in an efficient and effective manner. This plan includes tailored, localised approaches by redefining data, and increased use of different methods of aerial operations to conduct treatment and surveillance activities on a larger scale.

In addition, NMG members approved the introduction of an eradication treatment protection area, which will involve the program conducting responsive treatment up to 2 km inside the 2024-25 planned eradication treatment area. This change will strengthen the program's response to recommendation 6 of the Strategic Program Review.

Members were updated on progress towards the 2023-24 work plan, prioritising eradication activities on the Gold Coast, Scenic Rim and Southern Downs. The program has since extended eradication activities to include treatment in the Lockyer Valley, Somerset and Moreton Bay. The program has also been responding to outlier detections in Murwillumbah and Wardell. The 2024-25 workplan will nearly double the program's target area.

The NMG congratulated NFAEP on its decisive and professional response to detections in Oakey, Meringandan West and Nirimba. Members noted and acknowledged the program's effort to deliver significant outcomes, while overcoming challenges presented by above average inclement weather activity in Queensland and Northern New South Wales.

Since the last NMG meeting, the newly formed governance committees which includes the NFAEP Risk Management and Assurance Committee, the NFAEP Consultative Committee and the Contingency Options Planning Group have all met.

A plan for quarterly industry engagement forums has been endorsed by NMG members to ensure relevant stakeholders remain well informed about the progress of fire ant eradication.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/rifa-may-june-2024>